



THE New Corolla sits off Huntington Beach on Friday. The crude oil tanker left Iraq just before the Iran war.

Newsom budget puts his legacy on the line

Will governor solve the chronic spending deficit or kick the can to eventual successor?

By TARYN LUNA

SACRAMENTO — One of Gavin Newsom's top goals as he winds down his final year as California governor is to leave the state with a balanced budget.

After years of the state spending more money than it brings in, it's Newsom's last opportunity to fix a chronic deficit or dump the problem on the next governor.

How far he goes to solve the state's structural spending imbalance will define his legacy as a steward of trillions in taxpayer dollars. As a potential candidate for president in 2028, he could also have a political incentive to do as little as possible.

"Any cuts you make are going to cause people to scream," said Darry Sragow, a veteran Democratic strategist. "Any increases in taxes are going to cause people to scream and in terms of what's best for a presidential run, it would be nice if people weren't screaming."

As California's 40th governor, Newsom expanded publicly funded healthcare to income-eligible undocumented immigrants, increased state-subsidized child-care slots and provided free meals for schoolchildren among a wish list of progressive wins since he took office in 2019.

His achievements have helped struggling Californians live in an increasingly unaffordable state and given him bona fides to tout to voters if he launches a bid for the White House.

But the state could never

[See Budget, A11]

Last tanker may augur California oil shortage

Ship that left before war is final delivery from gulf

By BLANCA BEGERT

The last California-bound oil tanker to pass through the Strait of Hormuz since war erupted is at the Port of Long Beach offloading its valuable cargo — 2 million barrels of crude destined to be transformed into gasoline, jet fuel and diesel.

The New Corolla loaded up in Iraq on Feb. 24 — just days before U.S. and Israeli forces launched attacks on Iran, plunging the region into turmoil and sparking a double blockade of commercial shipping.

In two weeks, the Hong Kong-flagged tanker will have fully unloaded at the Marathon Petroleum terminal and departed again for

distant waters. After that, California must figure out how to replace some 200,000 barrels of oil a day that will no longer be arriving from the Persian Gulf.

California's own supply of crude oil has been declining since the 1980s, due to aging fields and a geology that makes drilling particularly costly. The state's gasoline refining capacity is also falling off, increasing reliance on imports and highlighting California's status as an isolated energy island without gas pipelines to bring in supply from other states.

Now, with the end of the Middle East conflict nowhere in sight and the average cost of California gaso-

line topping \$6 per gallon, some lawmakers are warning of potential oil and gas shortages.

So far during the Iran war, oil deliveries to California have remained relatively steady. The state imports about 75% of its oil from foreign countries and Alaska. Last year it brought in a mix from Brazil, Iraq, Guyana, Canada, Ecuador, Argentina and Saudi Arabia as its top international suppliers, with about 30% coming from the Middle East.

In March and April, that mix didn't change much, with California receiving about 21% and 14% of its foreign oil from Iraq and Saudi

[See Oil, A9]

Iran war: Nobel-winning activist ailing; U.S. threatens shipping firms. WORLD, A3

DOJ case sidelines hate group monitor

Allegations against law center threaten its mission in California

By Sonja Sharp



JACQUELYN MARTIN Associated Press

ACTING Atty. Gen. Todd Blanche seen as charges are announced against the Southern Poverty Law Center.

Experts who monitor far-right extremism have tracked a resurgence in California in recent years.

There are nearly 100 "hate and anti-government" groups in the state, including anti-vaxxers, doomsday prepper militias and old-school neo-Nazi outfits, according to the latest publicly available data from the Southern Poverty Law Center.

For years, the Alabama-based nonprofit, also known as the SPLC, has been one of the few nongovernmental organizations paying close attention to California's fringe. But now, after the Trump administration's announcement of federal charges against the center for alleged fraud, it's unclear how its work will continue.

Some are particularly concerned about California, long a hothouse for extremist groups.

"These kinds of groups have deep tentacles in Southern California," said Peter Simi, a professor of sociology at Chapman University and an expert on hate groups in the state. "You had a substantial pres-

[See Hate groups, A10]

New predator in wildlife kingdom: AI deepfakes

By LILA SEIDMAN

Shadow gingerly places one taloned foot, then the other, on Jackie as she hunkers down on the nest.

With Big Bear Lake glittering in the distance, he raises each foot in a kneading motion — evoking a bald eagle massage.

"Somehow, it says everything about their bond,"

reads the caption on the 15-second video posted to Facebook.

It looks tender. It looks real.

It isn't.

The clip is AI-generated.

Jackie and Shadow — made world-famous by a 24-hour livestream — aren't the only animals falsely depicted in deepfakes. AI wildlife videos have flooded social media platforms like

YouTube, Instagram and TikTok, racking up millions of views and likes. Some are whimsical, like a handful of bunnies hopping on a trampoline. Others take a more menacing tone, like a jaguar facing off with a dog in a snowy backyard.

Far from benign, some experts say the videos can skew how people view and even interact with wildlife — potentially leading to peril-

ous encounters. They may also undermine viewers' growing desire to tune into nature to escape the frenetic rhythms of daily life. Repeated exposure could erode trust in media and institutions generally, with one Reddit user proclaiming, "Can't even watch real animal videos because 90% of them are AI." There are also legal implications.

[See Deepfakes, A14]

From Caltech grad to alleged D.C. gunman

Cole Tomas Allen was known as a tutor, a gamer and 'a godly person' before arrest.

By CONNOR SHEETS, PAIGE ST. JOHN, ALENE TCHEKMEDYIAN, RUBEN VIVES AND JAMES QUEALLY

Before authorities charged him with attempting to assassinate President Trump and top administration officials in a brazen attack at the Washington Hilton, Cole Tomas Allen lived what those who knew him described as a quiet, simple existence.

He worked as a tutor and enjoyed video games, manga and riding his blue scooter. Acquaintances said Allen rarely talked about his political views through much of his adult life.

But on social media, he appears to have expressed concerns about the morality of U.S. policy, particularly its role in the wars in Ukraine and Iran.

Now, those who crossed paths with him are struggling to square the accusations against him with the

man they knew as an unassuming student, gamer and teacher.

Allen grew up in a middle-class, suburban part of Torrance, one of four siblings who would each go on to study at reputable universities. His parents were both teachers and "really solid members of their community," according to Paul Thompson, a Los Angeles County prosecutor who lives next door to the family's two-story house. Allen's father knew many people on the block of single-family homes by their first names, Thompson said, and the suspect's mother once saved Thompson's dog when it ran into the road.

As a high school junior, Allen led Pacific Lutheran's volleyball team in a three-set win over Junipero Serra High School. He was homeschooled, but was allowed via a special program to take a class at Pacific Lutheran in Gardena and to play for its respected squad, according to the private school's principal.

Allen was "a godly person" who never cursed or shared his political views at the time, a former teammate told The Times, but he was

[See Allen, A10]

A blow to in-home abortion access

Federal court ruling blocking the mailing of mifepristone could hit rural areas hard.

By BLANCA BEGERT

In the biggest jolt to abortion policy in the U.S. since the overturning of Roe vs. Wade, a federal appeals court has restricted access to one of the most common ways to end early pregnancies by blocking the mailing of mifepristone prescriptions.

The unanimous ruling Friday from the New Orleans-based 5th U.S. Circuit Court of Appeals marks a substantial victory for abortion opponents seeking to stem the flow of abortion pills prescribed online that they view as subverting state bans on the procedure.

It will apply in all states, including those without abortion restrictions. In California, where abortion re-

mains legal, residents, especially in the rural northern reaches of the state and the Central Valley, rely on telemedicine to access abortion care.

"California will continue to stand for a woman's right to choose — and fight like hell against those who seek to reach across our border and tear that fundamental right away," Gov. Gavin Newsom said in a statement.

The ruling, which drug-makers are expected to appeal to the U.S. Supreme Court, requires that mifepristone be distributed only in person and at clinics, overruling regulations set by the federal Food and Drug Administration.

Friday's ruling is in effect while the case works its way through the courts, but a mifepristone manufacturer has asked the appellate court to put its ruling on hold until the Supreme Court weighs in.

Frustrated with a lack of

[See Ruling, A11]



STEPH CHAMBERS Getty Images

GOLDEN TEMPO BY A NOSE

Jockey Jose Ortiz kisses the victorious horse after winning the 152nd running of the Kentucky Derby at Churchill Downs. **SPORTS, D1**

Spirit Airlines abruptly closes
After a bailout attempt fizzles, the carrier shuts down. Some ticketed passengers were caught unaware. **NATION, A6**

Weather
Low clouds clearing. L.A. Basin: 69/56. **B8**

Opinion Voices A16
Obituaries B4

Take flight with the pages inside
Build your own kite with a how-to that lets you put the paper to playful use. **WEEKEND, L6**

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